Nehru met with Mustafa al Nahhas Pasha (1879–1965), leader of the Wafd party and later prime minister of Egypt, during a 1938 trip to Cairo.[7] A Wafd party delegation later attended the annual session of the Congress party in 1938–39. In 1939, Nehru visited China and established contacts with leaders of the Kuomintang government including Chiang Kai-shek.[8] The Indian National Congress organized a boycott of Japanese goods in response to Japanese aggression against China and also sent a medical mission under Dr Kotnis in support of the Chinese resistance.

By the time Viceroy Lord Archibald Wavell formed India's interim government in September 1946 in anticipation of Independence, Nehru had sufficient international exposure to be assigned the portfolios of external affairs and Commonwealth relations. In his first radio broadcast in that capacity on 7 September 1946, Nehru stated that India would try 'as far as possible, to keep away from power politics of groups, aligned against one another'. Nehru envisioned the world as one torn apart by 'rivalries and hatreds and inner conflicts' and envisaged India's role as working towards 'a world commonwealth'.[9] In a speech given on the floor of the Constituent Assembly on 13 December 1946, Nehru laid out the broad contours of his foreign policy: 'This ancient land attains its rightful and honoured place in the world and makes its full and willing contribution to the promotion of world peace and the welfare of mankind. We approach the world in a friendly way. We want to make friends with all countries.'[10] For Nehru, these were not just words but deeply held beliefs.

Over the years, Nehru repeatedly asserted that his foreign policy was not something crafted by him alone. 'It is a policy inherent in the circumstances of India, inherent in the past thinking of India, inherent in the whole mental outlook of India, inherent in the condition of the Indian mind during the freedom struggle and inherent in the circumstances of the world today.'[11]

However, Satchidananda Murty argues convincingly that there was nothing inevitable about the way India's foreign policy evolved and the